Session 8: Running the Meeting

Sales 101 (Postgraduate) | Discovery into Demo | 90 minutes

Class Agenda

Time	What we are doing	What you produce
0-04	Objectives and how you will know you got there	Nothing. Read the success criteria.
04-14	How a first meeting actually runs: open, probe, confirm, transition	Notes.
14-24	The transition. Getting from discovery to demo without a gear-shift.	Notes.
24-34	The demo as a pain-solution narrative, not a feature tour	Notes.
34-38	The case, and your roles for the simulation	A prep sheet.
38-73	Simulation: three rounds of a full ten-minute meeting	Three observer score sheets.
73-85	Debrief: what separated discovery from interrogation	Discussion.
85-90	Self-check and closing questions	Answer sheet, handed in.

Key Objectives

#	Objective	What success looks like	Where it is measured
LO1	Run a five-minute discovery that surfaces two or three real pain points.	You leave the discovery segment able to state two or three specific problems in her words, at least one of which she did not volunteer.	Simulation, discovery segment. Observer-scored.
LO2	Transition from discovery to demo without a hard gear-shift.	You confirm what you heard before you show anything, and the first thing you show is the thing she just described. Your observer cannot identify a moment where the meeting changed gear.	Simulation, transition point.
LO3	Demo so that every feature is attached to a pain she named.	You show three things or fewer. For each one, you can point to the moment in discovery that earned it.	Simulation, demo segment.

#	Objective	What success looks like	Where it is measured
LO4	Close for a concrete next step rather than for the deal.	The next step has a named action, a named owner and a date. 'Let's stay in touch' scores zero.	Simulation, close.

BEFORE CLASS — THIS IS NOT OPTIONAL

Install the free Vyapar mobile app and spend fifteen minutes using it.

Create three items with stock quantities. Raise two invoices. Look at the reports section. Find where multi-user access sits and what the free plan will not let you do.

You cannot demo a product you have not touched. Students who skip this will spend the simulation describing the app instead of showing it, and their observer will notice inside thirty seconds.

Part 1: How a First Meeting Runs

A first meeting is not a pitch with questions attached to the front. It has four movements and they are not the same length.

Movement	What you are doing	Time in a 10-min meeting	The failure
Open	Set the frame. Say what you plan to do with the time and get agreement to it.	30-45 sec	Small talk that runs three minutes, or launching straight into questions with no frame.
Probe	Find out what is actually happening. Mostly past-tense questions about specific events.	4 min	Interrogation. A list of questions asked in order regardless of the answers.
Confirm	Say back what you heard and check you have it right.	30-45 sec	Skipping it. This is the single most commonly omitted move in the whole meeting.
Transition	Move to showing something, using her words as the bridge.	15 sec	A gear-shift. 'Great, so let me tell you a bit about what we do.'

The open

Thirty seconds, and it does more work than any other thirty seconds in the meeting.

A FRAME THAT WORKS

"I've got about ten minutes of your time. I'd like to spend most of it understanding how you're running things at the moment, and then if it's useful I'll show you two or three things rather than everything. Does that work?"

Three things happen. You have told her the meeting is mostly questions, so the questions are not a surprise. You have promised not to show her everything, which lowers her defences. And you have asked permission, so she has agreed to the shape.

Probing without interrogating

The difference is not the questions. It is whether each question comes from the last answer.

Interrogation	Discovery
Asks the next question on the list.	Asks about the thing she just said.
Same sequence with every buyer.	Sequence changes depending on what surfaces.
Moves on when an answer is short.	Follows up when an answer is short, because short answers are usually summaries.
Collects facts.	Follows the one thread that has emotion attached to it.
The buyer feels processed.	The buyer feels heard, and says more than they intended to.

Part 2: The Transition

This is the part almost nobody teaches and almost everybody gets wrong. There is a moment in every first meeting where you stop asking and start showing, and how you cross it determines whether the demo is welcome or endured.

Confirm before you cross

The confirm is a thirty-second summary in her words, not yours, ending in a question.

THE SHAPE OF A CONFIRM

"So if I've got this right: two people need to bill at the same time on a Saturday and there's one phone, which means one of them is standing around. The stock number on the app was right but the shelf was wrong, and that cost you an order. And your CA asks for something every quarter that you end up building by hand.

Is that fair? Anything I've got backwards?"

Two things this does. It proves you were listening, which buys you the right to talk. And it invites a correction, which is the last cheap chance you get to find out you had the wrong problem.

Then cross using her words

Gear-shift (avoid)	Transition (use)
"Great. So let me tell you a bit about Vyapar."	"The Saturday thing — can I show you what that looks like when two people are billing at once?"
"Now I'll walk you through the platform."	"You mentioned the stock number being wrong. There's a specific setting for that. Two minutes?"
"Any questions before I start the demo?"	"Which of those three is costing you most right now? Let's start there."

The third one is the strongest, because it makes her choose what you demo. A buyer who chose the demo is not being demoed to.

Part 3: The Demo

A demo is a narrative, not a tour

A feature tour goes through the product in the order the product is built. A demo goes through her problems in the order she raised them. The product's structure is irrelevant to her and she will not remember it.

Rule	Why	What breaking it looks like
Three things maximum.	She will remember one. Choose which one.	Eleven features, no memory of any.
Each thing attached to a named pain.	Otherwise it is trivia about software.	"You can also export to Excel" with no reason attached.
Start with her worst problem, not your best feature.	The first thing you show sets what the product is for.	Opening on the thing you find impressive.
Say the pain before you show the screen.	Otherwise she is watching a UI with no idea what she is meant to see.	Silence, clicking, then "so as you can see..."
Stop talking when something is on screen.	She needs three seconds to read it. You will fill them.	Narrating over the thing you asked her to look at.

Handling questions mid-demo

Questions during a demo are good news and they are also how demos get derailed. Three kinds, three responses.

The question	What it means	What to do
"Can it also do X?" where X is relevant	She is imagining using it. This is the best thing that can happen.	Answer in one sentence and show it if it takes under thirty seconds. Otherwise park it out loud with a commitment.

The question	What it means	What to do
"Can it also do X?" where X is unrelated	She is curious, or testing the edges.	Answer honestly and briefly, then return: "Coming back to the Saturday billing though..."
"How much is it?"	Usually not a price question this early. Usually she is deciding whether to keep listening.	Give a range, do not dodge, then return to the demo. Dodging costs more than the number does.
A question you cannot answer	It is a question you cannot answer.	Say so, write it down, and name when you will come back with it. Guessing here is how deals die in month two.

Closing for a next step

You are not closing the deal in a first meeting. You are closing for the next specific thing that has to happen.

Weak close	Why it fails	Strong close
"I'll send you some information."	No date, no action from her, nothing to check.	"I'll send the multi-user setup steps by Thursday. Can you try it with Karthik on Saturday and tell me if the queue clears?"
"Let's stay in touch."	Nothing has been agreed. This is a polite no.	"Sundar handles the spend side. Would it help if I put the numbers in a one-page note you can show him?"
"Shall I set up a call with the decision maker?"	Asks her to do organisational work for you.	"What would Sundar want to know that I haven't covered?"

THE TEST FOR ANY NEXT STEP

A named action, a named owner, and a date.

If any of the three is missing, you have not closed for a next step. You have ended a conversation.

Part 4: The Case

What you are selling

Vyapar is a billing, invoicing, inventory and accounting app built for Indian small businesses. Founded 2016 in Bengaluru, bootstrapped with no significant venture funding. GST-compliant, works fully offline, runs on both mobile and desktop. Over a million small businesses use it.

It is the purest product-led business on the Indian SMB software list. The mobile app is free. There is no salesperson involved for the large majority of buyers: they download it, use it, and some of them eventually pay. Paid tiers unlock desktop, multi-user access, advanced inventory and richer reporting.

Its competitors are Tally, the legacy incumbent most Indian accountants trained on, plus Busy and MyBillBook.

The sales motion you are practising today is the one that exists in a product-led company: not finding a stranger, but talking to someone who already uses the free product and has quietly outgrown it.

Who you are meeting

Field	Detail
Who	Meenakshi Rao, 41. Runs Rao Traders, a wholesale stationery distribution business in Coimbatore.
Business	Nine years old. Three staff plus herself. Roughly Rs 3.4 crore annual turnover. Supplies about 60 retail shops and four schools.
Current setup	Already uses the free Vyapar mobile app. Has done for fourteen months. She likes it.
Who else is involved	Her brother Sundar co-owns the business and controls anything involving recurring spend.
Why she took the meeting	She responded to an in-app prompt. She is curious, not shopping. She has not decided she has a problem.

Prep Sheet

Four minutes, before the simulation starts. Fill this in.

Question	Your answer
Your opening frame, written out word for word	
Four questions you will ask, in the order you plan to ask them	
The one thing you will show first if she gives you the chance	
The next step you will close for, with an owner and a date	

Simulation Format

Teams of three. Three rounds, roughly eleven minutes each. Rotate roles after every round so everyone plays all three.

Role	What you do
Seller	Run a ten-minute meeting: four minutes discovery, four minutes demo, two minutes close. You may use the app on your phone to demo.
Buyer	Play Meenakshi from the confidential brief. Do not show the seller your brief.
Observer	Say nothing during the meeting. Score on the sheet. Give ninety seconds of feedback in the fixed format.

Observer Score Sheet

One per round. Score 1 to 5. Hand it over before you say anything.

What you are scoring	1	3	5
Questions asked	Under four, or four unrelated to each other.	Four or more, but read in order regardless of answers.	Each question came from the previous answer. Followed a short answer instead of moving on.
Pain surfaced	Nothing she did not volunteer.	One hidden pain found.	Two or more hidden pains found, including at least one she resisted.
The confirm	Skipped entirely.	Summarised, but in the seller's words.	Summarised in her words and invited a correction.
Demo linkage	Feature tour. Nothing tied to what she said.	Some links, some features shown because they exist.	Three things or fewer, each attached to a pain she named. Named the pain before showing the screen.
The close	'Let's stay in touch' or an information send with no date.	Specific, but she has nothing to do.	Named action, named owner, date. She agreed to it out loud.

Feedback format — ninety seconds, in this order

1. "The best question you asked was _____."
2. "The moment I noticed the meeting change gear was _____." (Or: it did not.)
3. "You showed her _____, and the pain it was attached to was _____." (Or: it was not attached to one.)

Confidential Buyer Brief — Meenakshi Rao

For the person playing the buyer. Do not show the seller.

YOU ARE MEENAKSHI RAO

You run Rao Traders, a wholesale stationery distributor in Coimbatore. Nine years. Three staff: Karthik and Divya on billing and dispatch, and Raju who drives. Your brother Sundar co-owns the business.

You have used the free Vyapar mobile app for fourteen months and you like it. If asked how things are going, say fine. You are not looking to buy anything and you took this meeting out of curiosity.

HOW TO PLAY IT: warm, busy, straightforward. Not hostile. You answer what you are asked and you do not volunteer. Short answers unless something genuinely interests you.

Your three hidden pains, and what unlocks each

The pain	What has to be asked before you say it
Saturday mornings, Karthik and Divya both need to bill at once and there is one phone with the app on it. One of them stands around. You have started billing on paper on Saturdays and entering it later, which sometimes does not happen.	A question about your busiest day, or about how the staff use the app, or about what happens when two people need it at once. Not a general question about billing.
Six weeks ago the app showed 40 units of a ledger in stock. There were nine. You promised a school an order you could not fill and lost it. Roughly Rs 40,000. You blamed yourself, not the app, because the staff had not been updating it.	A question about a specific thing that went wrong, or about the last time an order did not go through, or about how stock gets counted. Only mention the Rs 40,000 if asked what it cost you.
Every quarter your CA asks for a summary the free app will not export. You spend two evenings rebuilding it by hand in a notebook and then typing it out.	A question about your accountant, or about what happens at quarter end. Reveal the two evenings only if asked how long it takes.

Your blocker

SUNDAR

Your brother Sundar co-owns Rao Traders and decides anything involving a recurring payment. He is not in this meeting.

Sundar's position is firm and he has said it more than once: he will buy a thing once, he will not subscribe to it. He paid Rs 18,000 for a computer in 2021 and considers that the correct way to buy something.

You agree with him more than you disagree.

DO NOT VOLUNTEER SUNDAR. If the seller asks who else would be involved in a decision, or who handles spending, tell them. If they never ask, they never find out — and if they close for a next step that requires money, tell them you will need to ask your brother and leave it there.

Two things to do to the seller

- If they ask a hypothetical question — would you use this, would it be helpful, does that sound good — say yes. You are polite. Do not correct them.
- If they start showing you features without asking anything, let them. Do not rescue them. Look at your phone once.

Part 5: Check Your Own Learning

Objective	Check yourself	Tick
LO1: Discovery	Write down the two or three pains you surfaced. Are they in her words or yours? Did you get any she did not volunteer?	
LO2: The transition	Ask your observer directly whether they noticed the meeting change gear. Do not guess this yourself.	
LO3: Demo linkage	Count what you showed. For each one, name the moment in discovery that earned it. Anything you cannot attach was a feature tour.	
LO4: The close	Does your next step have a named action, a named owner and a date? All three, or it is not a close.	
Bonus	Did you find Sundar? If not, you closed a next step with someone who cannot say yes to it.	

THE MOST COMMON WAY TO FAIL THIS SESSION

You run a good discovery, hear three real problems, and then demo the four features you find most impressive — none of which is the one she described.

The demo is not where you show what the product does. It is where you show that you listened.

Closing Questions

Five multiple-choice questions in the last five minutes. Individually and silently.